

SESSION EIGHT: THE UNKEPT VIGIL

The Qilvayas Symphony

An adventure for 4–6 characters of 7th level — the rite floor, the last champion, and the funeral that never happened

OVERVIEW

Beyond the Witness Hall lies the Rite Floor, and on it, still speaking his half of a covenant into the dark, Threnvos. He is present, responsive, and worn past everything except the ceremony — two thousand years of grief have taken language, memory, and self, and left only the words he was saying when it happened. He cannot answer questions. He says his part, and waits for a response that never came, and begins again.

The session's work is the Vigil: someone sits, someone watches, someone speaks the responses nobody spoke. It takes the whole night — which means the party must commit to remaining in the dark until a dawn they cannot see. The hunger that shares his grave will try to stop them, because the Vigil is the only thing that can take anything away from it. And when the Vigil is kept, the grief goes out of the room, and the room gets colder, and what remains does not grieve, does not remember, and wants nothing except more.

Designed for a five-hour core. Pacing budget: the arch, the vestibule, and the first hearing (30 minutes); the Rite Floor and Threnvos (55 minutes); understanding what he needs, against three wrong answers that are all reasonable (45 minutes); setting the watch (15 minutes); the Vigil, in three watches with interruptions (75 minutes); the parting and the ascent (50 minutes). Optional content adds roughly 60 minutes. Milestone: 8th level at the Vigil's completion.

On the Vigil's timing. The previous budget gave the Vigil a flat 120 minutes. It is now 15 for the setting and 75 for the three watches at 25 each, which is 30 minutes less and considerably tighter, because the watches now have written interruptions and decisions rather than an open stretch to fill. The 30 minutes goes to the diagnosis scene and the ascent, both of which were underfed. If a table wants the old length, the place to spend it is the second watch: the private offer to each character is the scene most likely to be worth double its budget.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

Threnvos was killed by his sworn brother under the Matron's own witness and buried under a wall, under a forum, under a founding myth — with no Vigil, no watching, no light, and nobody to see him home. In a culture where doctrine holds that the Matron watches the dead home and does it at night, and that the Vigil is owed to the dead as dead and not as the good, that is not merely a cruelty. It is the wound. The thing beneath Aenodira is an unkept vigil two thousand years long, and it has been waiting in the dark for someone to sit with it.

The entity has two fused components: Threnvos's grief, which is a person and can be laid to rest, and the impersonal

hunger the broken covenant unleashed, which is not and cannot. Keeping the Vigil separates them. It is a real victory and it is not the victory: the grief goes quiet because it was the only part a funeral could touch, and what is left is hunger, fed for two centuries by an empire that keeps breaking its word and looking away. The party should feel this as loss — something recognizably personal leaves the world, and what remains is worse for being emptier. The nastiest implication is one they will reach on their own, probably on the walk up: the part they just gave peace to was the part that could, in principle, have been reasoned with.

This is the campaign's pivot from dungeon problem to civilization problem. What remains is fed by Norr's oath-web if he ever breaks it, by Vasq's unspoken order, by Karvel's coronation covenant sworn in the wrong direction, by every deserter at every Redwatch, and by every institution that looks away. Either the empire learns to keep its word, or the thing beneath it never stops eating — which makes the Zhuvedian Laws the actual weapon, and the Grey-Gold Rising considerably more than a set piece.

On the Matron: she may well be down here, and may always have been, keeping the vigil nobody else would. Divine magic works normally in the deep reach; clerics who pray receive. But there is never a form, never a voice, never a confirmation, and no amount of investigation resolves it — the ambiguity is permanent and deliberate. What sells it is the quality of the answer: two thousand years of doctrine about the She-Wolf who watches the dead home, and none of it prepares a devout character for the fact that what answers in this room is grieving.

SCENE 1: THE ARCH, AND THE FIRST HEARING

The western arch was never scoured, because nothing on it bore a name. Beyond it the stair goes down only a little further, and then the smell of cedar and resin is suddenly strong — the incense of a rite, in the moments before it begins — and under it, for the first time, you hear words. A voice. Not the breathing: a voice, speaking slowly and clearly in a language none of you know, in the cadence every one of you recognizes, because you have all sworn oaths in that cadence. It reaches the end of a phrase. It stops. It waits. The silence goes on a beat too long, and then a beat too long again, and then it begins the same phrase from the start.

Let the party listen. They will work out the shape before they understand a word: this is someone swearing an oath and pausing for a response that does not come. A DC 15 Intelligence (History), or any character with Old Imperial or academy liturgical training, recognizes the *form* — an antiphonal covenant-rite, the oldest kind, where two parties

alternate lines. Nobody at the table can translate the words yet. That is correct and intentional.

SCENE 2: THE RITE FLOOR

The chamber is not large. After the Hall it feels almost domestic — a room built for two people to stand close together in front of witnesses far above. Everything in it is paired: twin plinths, twin basins, two low stone seats, an approach from either side converging at the center. It is still set. Two thousand years and the vessels are still in place, the cloths still folded, the ceremony still laid out and waiting. And at the center, facing a place where no one stands, is what is left of the second champion.

On Threnvos's presentation: do not make him a monster and do not make him a ghost of the tragic-noble kind. He is a shape that the eye keeps failing to finish — tall, robed in the vestments' twin, features that resolve for half a second at a time and are Drow, and old, and unbearably tired. He does not menace. He does not notice the party at first. He is mid-rite and has been for two millennia.

WHAT HE CAN AND CANNOT DO

- **He speaks only the ceremony.** Grief has worn away language, memory, and self, and left the covenant — the way severe aphasia can take speech but leave a song known since childhood. He cannot answer questions, cannot explain the founding, cannot name Zhuvedus. Do not let him become an exposition dispenser; the truth comes from Vaelindra's names, the Tarnovari ballad cycle, and Nyreeza's documents, which is where it belongs.
- **He is a participant, not a recording.** He must demonstrably respond to the party specifically, or the whole scene reads as scripted. Three beats to deploy as they land: he goes silent and still if anyone speaks a sworn word aloud in this room, and waits, and then resumes when it is not the response; he turns toward whoever carries Dren's medallion and does not turn away again; and if a character who has broken an oath in play comes within ten feet, he stops mid-phrase, and something like recognition crosses whatever he has instead of a face, and it is not accusation — it is company.
- **He cannot be fought, and should not be.** He has no stat block by design. Attacks pass through him with the sensation of putting one's hand into cold water. If a party insists on hostility, the room grows colder and he keeps going, and eventually the players will feel the shape of what they are doing to a man who is trying to finish a wedding.

UNDERSTANDING WHAT HE NEEDS

The party has every piece required. They have kept a Vigil (Session One, if they did — and if they did not, this is where that omission returns). They know the doctrine: watched, lit, never left alone, owed to the dead as dead. They have just spent a session learning that witnessing lays the unquiet to rest (the Turned). And they are standing in front of a man who never got any of it. Let them assemble it. Nudges if needed, in escalating order: the ceremony pauses for a response; the second set of vestments in their pack; a devout character's training; and finally, if the table is truly stuck, a cleric who prays receives — not words, just the certainty of what is owed here, and the distinct impression that whatever answered is already doing it and has been for a very long time.

SCENE 3: THE VIGIL

The Vigil requires the full night: light kept burning, the dead attended, never left alone, and — here — the responses spoken. Every character knows the form; a devout one knows the patron, and his name is worth saying aloud down here. Coren the Unhurried kept four thousand nights, refused ordination six times, and was canonized by the parishes over the Sanctum's objection that his refusals were insubordinate — the empire's saint of night-work is a man the Church did not want and could not stop. Tonight is night four thousand and one, and it is the one that was always owed. Structure it as three watches, and put a real interruption in each. The hunger cannot stop them by force; it can only try to make them stop themselves.

RUNNING THE WATCHES

- **Watch One — the Cold.** The temperature drops hard enough to matter. Each character makes a DC 13 Constitution save at the watch's midpoint; failure means one level of exhaustion. Fire helps and the party will think of it. What the scene is really asking is whether they will spend resources on a corpse's comfort. (DM: the cold is not an attack. It is the room resisting being warmed. Describe it as reluctance, not malice.)
- **Watch Two — the Unwitnessed.** The hunger sends the only thing it has: four Unwitnessed (five for five characters, six for six), the shapeless residue of things that happened here and were not seen. They do not want to kill the party — they want the Vigil broken, and they target light sources, the vestments, and whoever is speaking the responses. A party that fights them while maintaining the Vigil (at least one character continuously attending, light kept) wins the encounter in the way that matters. A party that abandons the Vigil to fight cleanly must begin the watch again.
- **Watch Three — the Offer.** The subtlest and the best. In the small hours, the hunger stops attacking and starts talking — not aloud, and not to everyone: to one character, in the voice of the person whose promise they confessed in the Long Approach. It is not an illusion and not a charm, and it does not lie. It simply offers, with perfect sincerity, to let them go back and keep that promise instead. No save; nothing compels. The DM asks the player what their character does, and the answer is the character's. If they leave the Vigil, the others can complete it without them — and that character carries something for the rest of the campaign.

THE RESPONSES

Speaking Threnvos's missing half is the Vigil's substance, and no character knows the words. This is intentional. The party must improvise — whatever a character says, in whatever language, in the pauses he leaves. It does not need to be correct. It needs to be a response, offered in good faith, in the right place. Let the players write the second half of the founding covenant themselves, out loud, at the table.

Near dawn — you have no way to know it is dawn, and every one of you knows it anyway — he reaches the end of a phrase, and stops, and someone answers, and he does not begin again. For the first time in two thousand years the rite goes forward. He turns. He has no face to show you and he turns anyway, and something in the shape of him settles, the way a man sets down a weight he has carried so long he had stopped calling it a weight. He is not grateful. He is not

at peace, exactly. He is finished. And then he is not there, and the vestments in your pack are suddenly, ordinarily warm, and the cold in the room that was grief is gone entirely — and the room is colder than it has ever been.

SCENE 4: WHAT REMAINS

Give this its full time. The Vigil is complete, a man is at rest, and every instinct the party has says they have won. Then let them notice, one detail at a time, that the thing beneath Aenodira is still here — and that it is worse.

- The breathing has not stopped. It has changed: no longer slow and sleeping, but shallow and attentive, the sound of something that has just lost something and has not yet decided what that means.
- Dren's medallion is colder than it has ever been — and for the first time since Redwatch, whoever carries it can feel it *listening*.
- A character who prays receives, still. And whatever answers is no longer grieving. It is simply present, and waiting, and the difference between those two things is the entire back half of this campaign.

The party has separated a murdered man from the appetite that wore his grief as a face. What is left does not remember Threnvos, does not want justice, and cannot be reasoned with, because the part that could have been reasoned with is the part they just laid to rest. It has been fed for two hundred years by an empire that breaks its word and looks away, and it will keep eating as long as that continues. There is no monster to kill at the bottom of this hole. There is a civilization to fix.

The way out is the way they came. The Second Seal will not close behind them — the frost does not re-form. Let them notice that too.

SCENE 5: THE ASCENT, AND WHO TO TELL

They come up into Aenodira with the vestments, the rubbing, Nyreeza's notes, an archive shelf-mark, and the knowledge of what the empire is standing on. The session's last forty-five minutes belong to the decision that shapes the campaign's second half: who learns any of this.

- **Vaelindra:** She promised them the names when they came back alive. She keeps that promise — Zhuvedus, Threnvos, the Oathbreaker's fall, all of it — and she is the only person who can tell them the funeral was real and insufficient without it sounding like defeat. If they tell anyone, tell her first.
- **Shen:** Gets them the archive. The dynastic shelf-mark is beyond a mercenary company and routine for the Bureau of Correspondence. She will also, correctly, identify the rubbing as the most dangerous object in the empire, and ask a question the party may not want to answer: what do you intend to do with it?
- **Vell:** Can date the frieze, read the old orthography of the nine names, and will be the first person to say aloud that the Golden Tablets postdate the Hall. He will need to sit down.
- **The throne:** Nyreeza's last instruction was do not follow, and the party now knows why — and also knows the

Laws are the weapon. Telling Qilvayas is no longer a betrayal of her wishes; it may be the completion of them. This remains the campaign's largest gate. Handle deliberately.

- **Nobody:** Also a choice. The Hall taught them exactly what it costs, and they will make it anyway if they are frightened enough, which is the most human ending this arc has.

Milestone: 8th level. The first arc of the campaign is closed: students, vision, Seeress, Proving, dead letters, the Seal, the Hall, and a funeral two thousand years late. The second arc is the empire itself.

THE RITE FLOOR, KEYED

Five areas, continuing the Undercourt's numbering from Session Seven. This is the end of the descent and the end of the arc, and it is small on purpose: after three hundred feet of Approach and a hall seating four hundred, the place the whole structure was built for is a single room.

C8. The Vestibule. Carried over from Session Seven. The dry basin, and the carving of two figures facing, one chiselled out. A party arriving here at the start of Session Eight should be given a moment to look at the remaining figure properly: it is Drow, and it is not Zhuvedus, because Zhuvedus is the one who was removed.

C9. The Rite Floor. Circular, sixty feet, sunk three steps below the vestibule, floor worked in a spiral of black stone that is not decoration but a path. At the center, the binding. The scene text carries this room; nothing in the keying replaces it.

C10. The Second Standing. A recess in the Rite Floor's western arc, at the spiral's outer end, sized for one person to stand in and see the whole floor. It is where a witness would have stood. It is empty, it has always been empty, and that is the entire crime.

C11. The Lamp Niches. Nine niches at head height around the floor's circumference, each holding a stone lamp, all nine dry. They are Vigil lamps and they predate the Church that would recognize them by twenty centuries. If the party lights them — and they will need oil they have carried three hundred feet — the room changes, and the DM should let that be the most beautiful thing in the campaign so far.

C12. Behind the Binding. There is nothing behind the binding. Stated here because parties will look, thoroughly, and a DM should be able to say so with total confidence and no hedging. The Undercourt has no secret door, no lower level, and no other exit. The way out is the way in, three hundred feet uphill, and everyone will feel every foot of it.

THE VIGIL (SET PIECE, IN THREE WATCHES)

The session's climax is a Vigil, and a Vigil is a night kept. Run it as three watches with a decision at each transition and an interruption in each. Nobody has to fight and something will try to make them.

Before the first watch — the Setting (15 minutes). The party decides how to keep it: who watches, in what order,

with what light, and whether they speak. The lamps at C11 can be lit if they have oil. The decision here is the whole set piece in miniature — a party that assigns watches carelessly is telling the DM how seriously they are taking this, and the module should let carelessness cost them.

The First Watch — Grief (25 minutes). What is here is grieving, and grief is loud. The interruption: the Rite Floor fills with the sound of a hall of four hundred people, all of them speaking at once, none of them audible, and the effaced benches upstairs are full. Nobody is there. The decision at the transition: does the watch hold? A character who leaves their post ends the watch and it must be restarted, and no mechanical penalty is needed — the other players will supply it.

The Second Watch — Hunger (25 minutes). What is here is also hungry, and the two are tangled, and separating them is the session's actual work. The interruption: an offer, made to whoever is on watch, individually and privately, in the voice of someone they trust. It is a real offer and it is specific to that character, and the DM should have prepared one per player. No save. Just the offer, and the silence after it. The decision at the transition: does the character tell the others?

The Third Watch — The Word (25 minutes). The last watch, and the only one where the party can speak. What is needed here is not a spell, a weapon, or a rite: it is a witness, standing in the Second Standing at C10, saying what happened. Anyone can do it. It requires no proficiency, no check, and no lore the party does not have by now. The decision at the transition is who stands there — and the module must not choose. If nobody does, the Vigil ends unkept, and that is a real ending and the Branch Ledger records it.

DM Only: the three watches are grief, hunger, and the word, and they map exactly onto what the campaign has been about since Session One: something was broken, something has been feeding on it, and the only thing that has ever repaired a broken oath in this world is somebody saying out loud what was actually done. There is no combat solution to the third watch. If the party attacks in the third watch, let them, let it be futile, and let the night end anyway at dawn, and let them live with it.

WHAT HE NEEDS (PUZZLE)

The session's puzzle is not a lock. It is a diagnosis: the party has to work out what Threnvos actually requires, and every wrong answer is a reasonable answer that a competent adventuring party would try first.

He is not attacking. He has not attacked. He has been here for two thousand years and the first thing he does is ask you a question, and the question is not the one you prepared for. Behind him the floor's spiral runs out to an empty standing at the western arc, and nine dry lamps look down from the wall, and the whole room is arranged around a shape that is not there.

Wrong answer one — destroy it. Available, survivable, and it ends the campaign's central thread badly. The thing here can be fought. It should be statted, it should be dangerous, and killing it accomplishes precisely nothing except that the Brekelands keep getting worse and nobody ever learns why.

Wrong answer two — release it. Also available. A party can undo the binding, and a party that has been paying attention

will be able to work out how. This is the worst available outcome and the module should not flinch from letting them choose it.

Wrong answer three — bargain. It will bargain. It will bargain in good faith, because whatever else is true of him, Threnvos kept his word and was killed for it. The bargain will be honored. It is still the wrong answer, because a new oath sworn on this floor is exactly how the first one went wrong.

Right answer one — the Vigil. Keep the night. Watched, lit, never left alone. The thing on this floor was buried unwatched two thousand years ago and every doctrine in the empire says that is a wound rather than a burial. A party that has met a single Vigil Hall has everything they need to work this out.

Right answer two — the witness. Stand in the Second Standing and say what was done. Not an apology and not a confession: testimony. The empty standing is the crime — there was supposed to be a witness at the founding and there was not — and a person filling it is the repair.

Right answer three — both. Which is what the room was built for, and which no party will get to without doing the first two separately and realizing they are the same act. Give this the full weight.

A note on equal solutions. The two right answers are genuinely equal and either alone is a complete ending. The Vigil without the witness leaves the grief settled and the account still open. The witness without the Vigil settles the account and leaves him unwatched. Both are good outcomes. Neither is the good outcome, and the Branch Ledger has a row for each.

HAZARDS AND THE LONG WAY BACK

The Dry Lamps (C11). No trap, one resource question. Nine lamps, and lighting all nine takes nine flasks of oil the party had to carry three hundred feet down. A party that brought four lights four. There is no penalty for lighting fewer and there is no bonus for lighting nine, and the DM should say nothing either way — but the room lit by nine and the room lit by two are different rooms, and the players will know which one they are in.

The Ascent. Three hundred feet uphill, after a night without sleep, on whatever oil is left. If the party is out of light, they walk it in the dark, roped, at half speed, for an hour of game time. This is not a hazard with a saving throw. It is the last thing that happens to them down here and it should be quiet.

The Arch, Going Out (C1). The dead wardline in the floor. Crossing it outbound, a character who kept the third watch feels nothing at all, and a character who did not feels the cold one last time. Say it to that player privately.

HANDOUT — SESSION EIGHT

THE FORTY LEGIBLE NAMES

(From the last forty benches in the Witness Hall, where the chisel broke. Forty names in an alphabet nobody at the table can read — but the party has a rubbing, and Session Six taught them who translates. Written out, they are ordinary names. Somebody's daughter. Somebody's neighbor. A cutler. Two children with the same family name.)

Note for the DM: these are the four hundred who were supposed to witness, and forty of whose names survive because a chisel broke. If the party reads them aloud during the Vigil, that is the third watch, and it counts, and the DM should recognize it immediately and without hesitation. It is the best available ending and no text anywhere in this module tells them it is possible.

OPTIONAL CONTENT (BEYOND THE FIVE-HOUR CORE)

The Vestments Returned (~30 minutes): The party carries the second champion's unworn ceremonial dress. Options with weight: burn them properly with a Vigil of their own at any shrine; carry them to Tarnovar, where a Voivode who does not know why will nonetheless know exactly what she is being handed; or give them to Qilvayas, which is either the kindest or the cruelest thing anyone has ever done to that man. No wrong answer; every answer is a scene.

What the Wolves Knew (~20 minutes): In the days after, the wolves of Aenodira begin returning to the Old Forum district — slowly, family by family, reversing three years of quiet exodus. Nobody in the city can explain it. A party with a companion wolf notices first, and a party that pays attention learns something true and unspoken: something down there is at rest that was not before. It is the only unambiguous good news this arc produces, and it arrives without commentary.

The Fourth Letter (~30 minutes): Nyreeza's abandoned drafts to her son can be finished — by the party, in her hand or their own, and delivered. The scene is not about whether Qilvayas believes it. It is about whether they choose to give a grieving man eleven words his mother could not finish. If the campaign ever opens the sealed dispatch case, this is the beat it will be measured against.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

Record outcomes in the Branch Ledger.

- **The Vigil kept, broken, or refused:** Kept: Threnvos is at rest permanently, the hunger is exposed and alone, and

the campaign proceeds as designed. Broken and resumed: the same outcome, one night later, with the party knowing they faltered. Refused entirely: Threnvos remains, the entity stays fused, and the campaign keeps a monster that can still be spoken to — a genuinely different and viable second half. Do not force the funeral.

- **Watch Three — who took the offer:** A character who left the Vigil to chase a kept promise carries it forward: they know they were offered their worst regret and reached for it, in front of everyone. No mechanical penalty. Considerable narrative weight, and the entity now knows exactly what that character is worth.
- **The responses, verbatim:** Whatever the players improvised as the covenant's missing half is now canon — the actual second voice of the founding rite, spoken two thousand years late by people who were not there. Write it down. If the campaign ever needs a counter-oath, a binding, or words to end things with, use theirs.
- **Who they told:** The single largest branch in the campaign. Vaelindra opens the mythology; Shen opens the archive and the politics; Vell opens the scholarship and the scandal; the throne opens everything at once and cannot be closed; nobody preserves the status quo at a cost the Hall already named. Sessions Nine onward are built from this answer.
- **Did they keep the Redwatch Vigil (Session One)?** If yes, the party arrives at the solution here intuitively and the DM should reward the callback openly. If no, make the omission felt — not punitively, but the realization that they have done this wrong once before, to eight men in a ruined fort, should land somewhere in this session.
- **Standing moved this session:** Standing moves only when they surface, and the Ascent is where. Vaelindra's circle goes to the top of the band if they come to her first, which she asked for and has earned — and because her circle and the Office are an opposed pair, telling her first is a decision about the Office as well. The Lupine Throne and the Court is not a tier tonight but a gate: bringing any of this to Qilvayas is a different campaign, and the Ledger has a row for it. Telling nobody costs nothing on any track in the empire, and is the only outcome in this document that the Witness Hall has an opinion about.

STAT BLOCKS

The Unwitnessed

Medium undead (residue), chaotic evil

Armor Class: 13

Hit Points: 45 (7d8 + 14)

Speed: 0 ft., fly 30 ft. (hover)

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
8 (-1)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	6 (-2)	10 (+0)	12 (+1)

Damage Resistances: cold, necrotic; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Damage Immunities: poison

Damage Vulnerabilities: radiant

Condition Immunities: charmed, exhaustion, frightened, grappled, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned, prone, restrained

Senses: darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10

Languages: —

Challenge: 3 (700 XP)

Residue. The Unwitnessed are the shapeless remainder of things that happened in this place and were not seen. They have no faces because they never had witnesses — not the same condition as the Turned, and a scholar will notice the difference.

Break the Watch. The Unwitnessed prioritize, in order: open flames and light sources, the ceremonial vestments, and whoever is currently speaking the responses. They will pass up an easy kill to snuff a lantern. They are not trying to win a fight; they are trying to end a funeral.

Incorporeal Movement. Can move through creatures and objects as difficult terrain, taking 5 (1d10) force damage if it ends its turn inside an object.

ACTIONS

Smothering Touch. Melee Spell Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 13 (3d6 + 3) necrotic damage. If the target is holding a light source, it must succeed on a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw or the light is extinguished.

Quench (Recharge 6). All nonmagical light within 20 feet gutters and dies. Magical light of 3rd level or lower is suppressed for 1 round. The dark is the point.

Threnvos has no stat block, by design. He cannot be fought, damaged, banished, turned, or compelled. If a DM ever needs a number for him, the number is the Vigil.

NPC NOTES — WHAT IS DOWN THERE

As in Session Seven: nothing living, and one thing worth knowing how to play.

- **The Unwitnessed, addressed.** Not the Turned, and the difference matters at the table. The Turned had witnesses and refused to be them; the Unwitnessed never had any at all — they are the residue of things that happened in this place and were seen by nobody. There is no memory in them to name and no gaze to hold, so the Session Seven solution does not work, and a player who tries it should fail visibly and safely. What reaches them is the Vigil itself: being kept, watched, and lit by someone who chose to stay. They are not trying to win the fight. They are trying to end the watch.
- **Playing the difference.** A scholar character notices it immediately (no check — they have just spent a session on the Turned). Let that character be the one who says it out loud, and let the table feel the correction: this is not a puzzle they have already solved. The counter is not cleverness. It is somebody standing still in the dark with a light, doing the oldest thing their people do.

DM Only: the Unwitnessed are the campaign's cleanest statement of its own thesis, and they should never be explained on the page to players. A thing that happened and was not seen does not stop existing; it becomes shapeless, hungry, and permanent. Every unkept oath in the fiction above them is making more of these. If the party asks what

happens to the Unwitnessed after the Vigil is kept, the honest answer is that nobody knows, because until tonight nobody had kept one.

LOOT AND FOUND REWARDS — SESSION EIGHT

Find	Value / Effect
The completed Vigil	No mechanical reward. The DM should offer none and the party should not ask.
The vestments, warm	After the Vigil the second champion's dress is ordinary cloth, ordinary temperature, two thousand years old and perfectly preserved. Whatever the party does with it is a scene (see Optional Content).
The covenant's second half	Whatever the players improvised, now canon and recorded. Arguably the most valuable object the campaign will ever produce.
The Rite Floor vessels	Pre-imperial ceremonial silver, paired, undecayed — 400 gp to a collector, and the party will not sell them, and the DM should let them not sell them.
The wolves' return	Not an item. Not a reward. The only unambiguous good news in this arc (see Optional Content).

REWARDS AND ADVANCEMENT

Coin: none, unless someone sells the Rite Floor silver for its 400 gp, and the DM should let the table decide that without comment. Items and intangibles: the vestments, warm now; the covenant's second half, in whatever words the players improvised, recorded verbatim in the Branch Ledger; the knowledge of what the empire is standing on; and a decision about who to tell, which is the heaviest thing they carry up the stair. XP for tables using it: the Unwitnessed are worth 700 apiece, which again is nowhere near the pace of 8th level; as in Session Seven, the milestone governs and the tally does not. Milestone: 8th level when the Vigil is kept. The first arc of The Qilvayas Symphony is complete: forty hours, a funeral two thousand years late, and a civilization still to fix.

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"There is no monster to kill at the bottom of this hole. There is a civilization to fix."